המועצה
הישראלית
להתנדבות

When the Siren Sounds:

Emergency Kits for Children in Arab Municipalities

Ensuring no child is left behind - in shelter or at home.

Imagine a public parking lot in an Arab town in northern Israel. It is 2 AM. The sirens have just sounded, yet again. Three hundred people are huddled between cars. There is no private shelter, no activities, no plan. Among them, forty children.

This is not a hypothetical. It is the nightly reality for thousands of Arab families across Israel. Unlike many communities, Arab localities have a critical shortage of private bomb shelters (Mamads), or building-based shelters, forcing families to seek refuge in crowded public spaces: schools, community centers, kindergartens, and parking lots, that are wholly unprepared for the long hours of waiting, anxiety, and idleness that follow each alarm.

The Israeli Volunteering Council is uniquely positioned to respond. We already operate active Volunteer Leader programs in 10 Arab municipalities. The trusted relationships, the local knowledge, and the community infrastructure are already in place. Your investment activates them.

The Context: A Community Facing Layered Vulnerability

To understand the urgency of this intervention, it is important to recognize the cumulative pressures that Arab society in Israel was already carrying before the current escalation.

A Community Already Carrying Heavy Burdens

Before the war, Arab communities across Israel were living through a prolonged and deeply damaging wave of internal violence. **Years of gang-related shootings, organized crime, and widespread intimidation** left families in a state of chronic fear. For children in these towns, the arrival of war sirens was not a disruption of normal life, it was one more layer added to lives already marked by insecurity.

KEY FACT	Arab municipalities in Israel have a significantly lower rate of private bomb shelters compared to the national average. Approximately 46% of Arab residents in Israel live in buildings without standard protective spaces, compared to 26% of the general population. Of Israel's 11,775 public shelters, only 37 are located in Arab municipalities, and 8 of those are unfit for use. (Israel Democracy Institute, 2024)

The Resource Gap: Why Aid Does Not Always Arrive

In emergencies, communities with fewer private shelters and greater language barriers are often slower to receive organized support, not due to intent, but due to logistics: distance from central distribution hubs, language gaps, and the difficulty of navigating formal systems under pressure.

The existing presence of Volunteer Leaders inside these communities is the direct answer to this challenge. The Volunteer Leaders know their neighbors, speak the language, and are trusted. They can reach every family, including those who would otherwise fall through the cracks.

Our Solution: Skilled Leadership, Activity Kits, and Practical Tools

We are not starting from scratch. The community infrastructure, the trusted and recognized Volunteer Leaders, the local relationships, and the deep familiarity with the field — all of these already exist in Arab municipalities where the Israeli Volunteering Council operates, in partnership with the volunteering unit within each local authority.

This proposal seeks to activate and strengthen this existing infrastructure **across 10 Arab municipalities**, reflecting the full diversity of Arab society in Israel: Druze, Christian, and Muslim communities, from the Galilee and Carmel in the north to the Negev in the south. This is not a program designed for one sector alone. It is a program for everyone. The initiative will operate through three complementary pillars, combining skilled community leadership with practical tools for immediate implementation in the field.

OUR EDGE	The Volunteer Leaders are already inside these communities. We don't need to find them, train them from scratch, or earn their trust. We just need to equip them.

Pillar I: Emergency Leadership Training

Before and during the distribution, the Israeli Volunteering Council's professional staff will provide intensive training sessions for Volunteer Leaders on managing volunteerism in emergencies. Training topics include:

- Personal and community resilience: tools for leaders to manage their own stress while supporting others
- Sense of capability: Do's and Don'ts when working with traumatized populations and children under stress
- Emergency protocols: case-study workshops: real shelter scenarios with structured response frameworks
- Community mapping: identifying 'invisible' residents: the elderly, people with disabilities, isolated families
- Strengthening community cohesion: practical tools for creating stability and normalcy during prolonged emergencies

Pillar II: Distribution of Activity Kits

Volunteer Leaders will manage kit distribution based on lists provided by the local authority, ensuring targeted, efficient, and dignified delivery.

Group Shelter Kits

100 kits total | 10 per municipality

Multi-use kits for public shelters: board games, art supplies, and group activity guides in Arabic. Designed for facilitators to run structured activities with large groups of children.

Individual Creative Kits

2,000 kits total | 200 per municipality

Personal kits for children who cannot leave home due to disability or illness. Each kit provides an activity, a sense of normalcy.

Pillar III: Knitting for the Children, Meaningful Activity for Older Adults in Shelters

Long hours in public shelters are difficult for everyone, but especially for older adults, who often experience prolonged waiting with no structured activity, no sense of contribution, and little to occupy their hands or minds.

This pillar addresses that reality directly. Older adults in public shelters will receive knitting kits and simple, illustrated instructions to knit octopus dolls, small, soft figures with documented therapeutic benefits for young children. The octopuses they create will be distributed to children in the community who are struggling emotionally with the ongoing emergency situation.

There is no complex model here. The logic is straightforward: older adults benefit from having something purposeful to do with their time in the shelter, and children benefit from receiving a hand-made gift made by someone in their own community.

THE POWER OF THIS PILLAR	Long hours in a shelter are hard for everyone, but especially for older adults, who may be less mobile and more sensitive to the surrounding anxiety. Giving them something to make with their hands, for a child nearby, turns idle waiting into something purposeful. A small gift, made by a neighbor. That is enough.

Each knitting kit contains yarn, knitting needles, embroidery thread and needle, marker, filling material, and illustrated knitting instructions.

Expected Impact

- 2,100 children reached directly, in shelters and at home, with meaningful, therapeutic activities. Indirect reach: Estimated 5,000–7,000 children in rotating shelter environments
- Older adults in shelters engaged in purposeful, hands-on activity during long waiting hours. Hand-knitted octopus dolls distributed to emotionally struggling children, each made by a neighbor within their own community
- 100 Volunteer Leaders trained in emergency volunteer management, creating lasting municipal capacity
- 10 Arab municipalities equipped with both human and material resources for crisis response
- A replicable model of equity-centered emergency response that can be scaled to additional communities

- Psychological relief through play and structured activity, breaking the cycle of idle anxiety for hundreds of families

LASTING IMPACT	Long after the sirens fall silent, these municipalities will retain a trained cadre of emergency volunteer managers, a permanent investment in community resilience that extends beyond this crisis.

Budget Overview

Item	Unit Cost	Quantity	Total
Leadership Training Workshops (online, 10 municipalities)	$2,500	10	$25,000
Group Shelter Kits (board games, art supplies, Arabic guides)	$500	100	$50,000
Individual Creative Kits (for homebound/disabled children)	$40	2,000	$80,000
Octopus Knitting Kits — Volunteer Club (materials per kit; quantity TBD per municipality)	$30	**300**	**$9,000**
Logistics & Volunteer Coordination	—	—	$15,000
TOTAL PROJECT COST			**$179,000**

An Invitation to Partner

The Israeli Volunteering Council is uniquely positioned to deliver this response with speed, professionalism, and trust. We do not need to build new relationships or identify new leaders, they are already there, already engaged, and already waiting to serve their communities.

What they need now are the tools and the training to do it well.

Your partnership in this initiative is an investment in equity, in dignity, and in the resilience of communities that have been asked to carry too much, for too long.